Hence, the experiences of the Jews during the last time that a grand ideal came crashing down—in this case, the promise of the Enlightenment—can sometimes hinder, rather than enable, a nuanced understanding of the current predicament. In the twentieth century especially, antisemitism was intimately bound up with the ideological imperatives and institutional manifestations of totalitarian political movements. True, the themes they summoned may be eerily familar to our eyes and ears—we see today the revival of both the Nazi image of the Jew as an unctuous predator, and the Soviet image of the Jew as a conniving tribalist—but the physical embodiment of the complex of beliefs that now compose antisemitism adopts a thoroughly modern (some might say "post-modern") form.

In the twentieth century, both Nazi Germany and the Soviet Union, the two states that did more to advance antisemitism than any of their democratic peers, converted mob vilification of the Jews into government policy. The meshing in these two countries of party and state, and of executive and judiciary, under the tutelage of a supreme leader, effectively closed down the possibility for autonomous, societally-based, political action. Antisemitism was, in this incarnation, a series of gruesome policy measures shaped and implemented from on high, even as it struck an agreeable chord with many, perhaps even a majority, of non-Jewish subjects.

But no European government today directs state-driven antisemitic policies. Many, in fact, have designed and strengthened legislation in the opposite direction, while leaders like German Chancellor Angela Merkel have declared: "Jewish life is part of our identity and culture. It hurts me when I hear that young Jewish parents are asking if it's safe to raise their children here or the elderly ask if it was right to stay here."[17] In several countries, the absence of a constitutional instrument like the First Amendment in the United States means that Holocaust denial or even distortion is illegal (among the eight convictions which French courts have handed down to Dieudonné M'bala M'bala was a 7,000-Euro fine, in June 2008, for referring to Holocaust commemorations as "memorial pornography").[18] In the same vein, more general hate speech towards Jews can place the offender on the wrong side of the law.

What all this demonstrates is that however much governments legislate and seek to educate against antisemitism, they cannot eliminate it. And the reason they cannot do so is that, today, antisemitism thrives within the very same democratic spaces that its totalitarian practicioners of yesteryear set about eradicating.

These limits on government action permit us to grasp the profound change in the expression of antisemitism in our century. It is no longer the preserve

Copyright © 2016. Nebraska. All rights reserved.

Anti-Judaism, Antisemitism, and Delegitimizing Israel, Nebraska, 2016. ProQuest Ebook Central,